

Important Nicknames

Zephaniah 3:14-17

Sing, Daughter Zion; shout aloud, Israel! Be glad and rejoice with all your heart, Daughter Jerusalem! The LORD has taken away your punishment, he has turned back your enemy. The LORD, the King of Israel, is with you; never again will you fear any harm. On that day they will say to Jerusalem, "Do not fear, Zion; do not let your hands hang limp. The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you; in his love he will no longer rebuke you, but will rejoice over you with singing."

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

In the Old Testament, God's people had many nicknames. The prophet Zephaniah uses a couple of them in these verses: "Daughter Zion" and "Daughter Jerusalem."

"Daughter." He's saying that his people are like daughters to him, like children that he loves. He says he delights in them and rejoices when he thinks about them. My daughter was an important nickname for them because if God loved them like a child, he would help them if they were in trouble.

And they needed help! These verses say that God's people experienced "punishment" and had an "enemy." They were afraid. They were throwing their hands up and shrugging because they didn't know what to do. But God said to them, "My Daughter, do not fear."

God calls you his child, too. In Baptism, God said, "You're my daughter. You're my son." Those are important nicknames. If he loves you like a daughter, he will "take great delight in you" and "rejoice over you with singing." He will help you if you're in trouble.

And we need help! Just like God's people in the time of Zephaniah, we have the "punishment" we deserve because of our sins. We have an "enemy," the devil, who is trying to separate us from God. But God says, "My daughter, my son, do not fear."

We don't have to fear because God has an important nickname, too. Zephaniah 3:17 says, "The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves." The God who loves you like a daughter is a Mighty Warrior. He doesn't just want to help you; he can help you. He is mighty. He can protect you from everything that tries to harm you. He already has taken away our punishment of sin, and he has defeated our enemy. Whenever you're afraid, the Mighty Warrior says, "My daughter, don't be afraid. I'm strong enough to save you!"

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- How many nicknames that God gave to his people can you remember?
- What is God's nickname in these verses? (If you can't remember, go back and find it.)

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- What does it mean that God calls his people "daughter"?
- God is a mighty warrior. List some things he's strong enough to protect his people from.

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Describe a situation when it would be important for you to remember that God delights in you as his son or daughter.
- Share a story in the Bible where God showed that he is a mighty warrior.

Closing Prayer:

Dear heavenly Father, thank you for calling us your dear children in baptism. Help me not be afraid of the troubles I face this week. Remind me that you are a mighty warrior, and you are always with me. In Jesus' name. Amen.